Business Insights and Recommendations

Week 4: Consumer Complaints Trends and Response Intelligence Platform

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1. Summary

Bank of America complaint records from 1 May 2017 to 28 August 2023 (62,516 complaints) show seven main patterns. Each is supported by figures reproduced in SQL.

- **Concentration.** Checking / savings and Credit / prepaid card account for 65.6% of complaints.
- **One dominant issue.** Managing an account alone is 24.2% of all complaints.
- **Growth.** Complaints grew 64.5% from 2018 to 2022, and 11.3% on a like-for-like basis in 2023.
- **Timeliness indicator.** The recorded untimely share moved from under 1% (2017 to 2020) to 10.98% in 2021.
- **Fast forwarding.** Median forwarding interval is 0 days and only 0.70% of complaints exceed 30 days.
- **Recent peak.** July 2023 is the highest month (1,749), and 49.3% of it was still In progress.
- **Uneven data quality.** Sub-issue is missing for 96.4% of Mortgage complaints.

All findings describe what the recorded complaints show. A complaint is a consumer-reported issue and does not establish misconduct, and a recorded company response is not proof that a complaint was resolved.

2. Findings

Finding 1: Two products account for two-thirds of all complaints

Checking / savings and Credit / prepaid card together hold 65.6% of the 62,516 complaints.

- Checking / savings: 24,814 complaints (39.69%). Credit / prepaid card: 16,197 (25.91%). Together: 41,011.
- Adding Credit reporting (7,710) takes the top three to 48,721 complaints (77.9%).
- At the other end, Payday / personal loan has 333 complaints (0.53%) and Student loan only 39 (0.06%).

How to read it: *These are counts, not rates. The dataset has no customer or account numbers, so a product with more complaints may simply be a larger product.*

Dashboard: Pages 1 and 2 (product charts, Share of Complaints %).

Finding 2: One issue, Managing an account, is a quarter of all complaints

Managing an account is the most frequently reported issue, with 15,109 complaints (24.17% of the total).

- All 15,109 sit under Checking / savings, where they make up 60.9% of that product's complaints.
- The ten most frequent issues together account for 65.9% of all complaints.
- 63 of the 76 issues appear under only one product, so issue lists are largely product-specific.

How to read it: *Because issues belong to one product, comparing issue counts across products mostly reflects each product's own issue list, not a difference in how the products are handled.*

Dashboard: Page 2 (Most Frequently Reported Issues and the Product vs Issue matrix).

Finding 3: Complaint volume grew 64.5% between 2018 and 2022, but not evenly by product

Full-year complaints rose from 7,872 in 2018 to 12,953 in 2022.

- Credit reporting rose 144% (761 to 1,858), Credit / prepaid card 91% (1,804 to 3,445) and Checking / savings 63% (3,176 to 5,186).
- Mortgage fell 40% over the same years (1,294 to 774).
- 2023 has 9,131 complaints up to 28 August. On a like-for-like January to 28 August basis, 2023 is 11.3% above 2022 (8,201), not 29.5% below it as the raw year-over-year figure suggests.

How to read it: *2017 (from 1 May) and 2023 (to 28 August) are partial years, so their year-over-year changes are not like-for-like. A rise in complaints does not show whether service got worse or more consumers chose to complain.*

Dashboard: Page 1 (monthly trend) and Page 4 (annual trend).

Finding 4: The recorded share of untimely responses rose sharply from 2021

Across all years, 96.06% of records with a Yes or No value are marked timely (58,619 of 61,022) and 3.94% are not (2,403). That overall figure hides a large shift over time.

- 2017 to 2020: between 0.10% and 0.69% marked No (as few as 7 records in 2019).
- 2021: 10.98% (1,224 of 11,149). 2022: 4.38% (567 of 12,953). 2023: 6.84% (522 of 7,637 valid records).
- The highest single month is June 2021, with 389 of 934 records (41.6%) marked No.

How to read it: *This is the recorded indicator only. The data does not say why it changed. It could reflect real timing, or a change in how the indicator was recorded or processed, and it needs confirming with the data owner. It is not evidence of misconduct.*

Dashboard: Page 3 (Timely vs Untimely donut; use the Year slicer to compare years).

Finding 5: Most complaints are forwarded the same day, and long delays are rare

The CFPB forwarding interval is 0 days for the typical complaint.

- Median 0 days; average 1.22 days; 79.4% forwarded on the same day.
- 95% are forwarded within 5 days and 99% within 25 days. Only 435 complaints (0.70%) took more than 30 days; the longest was 275 days (complaint 4481803, Debt collection).
- The share over 30 days is highest for Vehicle loan / lease (1.42%) and Mortgage (1.41%) and lowest for Credit reporting (0.32%).

How to read it: *This interval is the time the CFPB took to forward a complaint. It is not the company's response time and says nothing about resolution. The Vehicle loan / lease base is small (633 complaints).*

Dashboard: Page 4 (interval distribution, interval by product, longest intervals table).

Finding 6: July 2023 is the highest month and the largest jump above trend, and half of it was still In progress

July 2023 recorded 1,749 complaints, 1.54 times the trailing 12-month average of 1,133, the largest such ratio in the dataset.

- The increase sits mainly in Checking / savings (883, against 423 in June) and Credit / prepaid card (483, against 281). Peak days were 12 July (183) and 13 July (148), mainly under Managing an account (425).
- 863 of the 1,749 July complaints (49.3%) were still In progress. In fact all 1,494 In progress complaints in the dataset were received on or after 12 May 2023.
- Complaints then tail off sharply in the last week of August (1 to 5 a day), which suggests the final days of the extract are thin.

How to read it: *The dataset has no narratives and does not explain the peak, so no cause should be stated. The In progress share shows these complaints were recent when the data was extracted, so their response outcomes are not yet known.*

Dashboard: Page 1 (monthly trend), Page 3 (In progress) and Page 4.

Finding 7: Data completeness differs a lot by product

Overall, 17.37% of complaints (10,858) have no sub-issue, but the gaps are concentrated in a few products.

- Sub-issue is blank for 100% of Money transfer / service, 96.4% of Mortgage and 93.1% of Payday / personal loan complaints, against 0.1% for Checking / savings.
- 96.47% of complaints (60,311) carry the public response category in which the company responded and chose not to provide a public response.
- 681 closed complaints have no public response recorded, and the data does not say why.

How to read it: *Sub-issue analysis is reliable for checking, credit card and credit reporting products but not for mortgages, money transfers or payday loans. Public response categories show very little variety.*

Dashboard: Page 2 (sub-issue drill-down) and Page 3 (Public Response Categories).

3. Recommendations

Each recommendation is tied to a finding and describes an action a complaint-monitoring team could take. None of them assumes that any complaint was justified.

#	Recommendation	Evidence	Suggested actions	Priority
R1	Add a monthly volume alert	Finding 6. A rule of 'above 1.25 times the trailing 12-month average' would have flagged 8 of the 64 months with a full 12-month history; July 2023 is the highest at 1.54 times.	Add a trailing 12-month average and ratio measure in Power BI and show flagged months on the Timeline page. Review each flagged month by product and issue within a week. Leave partial months (the last month of data) out of alerts.	High
R2	Focus root-cause review on the largest complaint drivers	Findings 1 and 2. Two products hold 65.6% of complaints, and Managing an account alone is 24.2%.	Review Managing an account (Checking / savings) and the top credit card issues (for example Problem with a purchase shown on your statement, 4,415) using complaint narratives and internal data, which this dataset does not contain. Track complaints per 1,000 accounts to separate volume from product size.	High
R3	Confirm and monitor the rise in recorded untimely responses	Finding 4. Untimely share rose from under 1% (2017 to 2020) to 10.98% in 2021 and stayed at 4.38% to 6.84% since.	Ask the data owner whether the Timely response indicator or its process changed around 2021 before drawing conclusions. Add a monthly untimely-rate view with In progress shown separately. Report the rate with its base (valid Yes/No records) every time.	High
R4	Close data gaps and define ambiguous values	Finding 7 and the data-quality log. Sub-issue is blank for 96.4% of Mortgage complaints; 681 closed complaints have no public response; 8 records say only Closed; Web Referral is undefined.	Request sub-issue capture or validation for mortgage, money transfer and payday loan complaints. Document the meaning of Closed, Web Referral and blank public responses in the data dictionary. Until then, keep the Not specified and Not recorded groups visible on the dashboard.	Medium

#	Recommendation	Evidence	Suggested actions	Priority
R5	Report trends on a like-for-like basis	Finding 3. The raw 2023 change (-29.5%) becomes +11.3% when the same January to 28 August period is compared.	Label 2017 and 2023 as partial years on every trend visual. Add a same-period (year-to-date) comparison measure for the current year. Exclude In progress and partial months when comparing response patterns across years.	Medium

4. How these figures were checked

- **Source.** Every figure comes from the cleaned dataset (Complaints_Clean in Power Query and the complaints_clean view in MySQL).
- **Validation.** The KPI figures were reproduced in Week4_Validation.sql (Sections 2 to 5, 25 PASS checks) and the main findings in Section 6 of the same script. A few descriptive figures (the 95th and 99th percentile forwarding intervals, the peak days in July 2023, the daily counts at the end of August 2023 and the monthly untimely rates for 2021 to 2023) were calculated separately and are not in the script.
- **Limits.** Findings describe associations and patterns only. Causes cannot be established from this dataset, which has no narratives, no account or customer counts, and covers one company.